

2026 Trade Deadline

Acquiring Reid Detmers

A model-driven evaluation for the Atlanta Braves rotation

Jonathan Merlin

Data through May 31, 2026

Executive Summary

Pursue Reid Detmers. Reid Detmers is a controllable mid-rotation left-hander whose underlying stuff grades well above his surface results, making him a fit for a rotation in need. His contact-independent estimators sit a full run below his 4.63 ERA. Signed at \$2.625M for 2026 with control through 2028, Detmers can provide stability for a playoff push in 2026 while providing surplus value for the next two seasons.

The Need

The Atlanta Braves sit atop the NL East at 45-22 with one of the best staff ERAs in baseball. This is their best chance to return to the World Series since they won it in 2021. The rotation has held up despite the early-season losses of Hurston Waldrep and Spencer Schwellenbach, both slated to return. However, this is a risky proposition to rely upon deep into October. Currently, the depth behind 2024 Cy Young winner Chris Sale is thin, with the next options being unproven prospects like JR Ritchie and veterans like Bryce Elder, Grant Holmes and Martín Pérez, all of whom have peripheral statistics that suggest regression. Another unfortunate injury to the group down the stretch could be devastating for Atlanta's championship aspirations.

I screened the trade market for starters whose stuff and peripherals outpace their surface results. Rather than paying the premium for the market's top rental, Tarik Skubal, my screen surfaced Angels LHP Reid Detmers.

Model Summary

Every grade in this report comes from one Stuff+ model that grades each pitch on shape quality and delivery characteristics. My model predicts the run value the pitch should produce reported as Stuff+, where 100 is league average and the standard deviation is 10.

The model trains on roughly 3.1 million pitches from 2022 through 2026, using velocity, induced vertical and horizontal break, spin rate, spin axis, release height, release side, extension, arm angle, the vertical and horizontal approach angles at the plate, and three fastball-relative differentials. Additionally, not all Sliders are the same, so I split them into sweeper, gyro, and traditional subtypes with k-means on horizontal break, vertical break, and fastball velocity gap. Grades are produced out of fold across five pitcher-level folds, so no pitcher ever trains on his own arsenal, and each pitch is standardized to a mean of 100 and standard deviation of 10 within its subtype, so a 104 slider means the same thing as a 104 curveball.

Target Variable. The target variable in this report is expected run value. Realized run value on balls in play is mostly luck, so training on it drags every grade toward the mean. I keep realized run value on the outcomes a pitcher controls, whiffs, called strikes, balls, hit-by-pitch, and fouls, and replace the ball-in-play term with expected run value from xwOBA on trackable contact. This way, grade describes the pitch, not the defense behind it.

The Deadline Screen

This grade can be used as a decision tool by comparing a starter's stuff+ rank against his results rank. Strong stuff with poor results is a potential buy-low candidate conversely, weak stuff with strong results could be due for regression. The gap between the two ranks is what I looked at to find optimal trade candidates.

Reid Detmers

The screen ranks Detmers in the 82nd percentile of starters on stuff but only the 58th on results, a 24-point gap suggesting that he isn't performing to the quality of his stuff making him a target for optimization and positive regression.

Pitcher	Stuff+	Stuff+ Percentile	RV/100 Percentile	Gap
Reid Detmers	102	82	58	24

Overview. Detmers' four-seam grades out as his weakest offering at 100.7 Stuff+ yet accounts for 44% of his pitches. His slider and curveball grade better and miss the most bats. Lowering fastball usage in favor of more sliders and curveballs is the fastest path to closing his stuff-results gap.

Pitch	Usage	Velo	IVB	Whiff%	Chase%	Stuff+
FF	44.0%	94.0	17.1	18.3	23.5	100.7
SL	30.9%	86.3	-3.6	33.0	45.3	104.0
CH	12.1%	83.4	10.9	29.2	32.4	101.1
CU	10.5%	72.5	-14.9	39.6	28.6	102.1
SI	2.5%	93.5	13.7	0.0	35.0	92.7

Optimization. At 94 mph with 17.1 inches of induced vertical break, Detmers' fastball is built to beat hitters up in the zone. However, his heat maps show him leaving it over the middle, specifically to righties. Cutting four-seam usage below 40% against RHH, shifting that usage to the slider and curveball, and locating the four-seam up would help the ride play while continuing to set up the breaking balls beneath it. Detmers relies on his slider as his primary out pitch, with far less reliance on his curveball. However, the curveball posts his highest whiff rate in the arsenal, despite being deployed as a strike stealer. It carries a 53% zone rate and a 44.1% CSW, the highest mark of any pitch he throws. Hitters chase it only 28.6% of the time but this seems to be due to Detmers intent, rather than the physical characteristics of the pitch. Adjusting the location of the curveball down below the zone in 2-strike counts can help convert

more of that whiff ability into actual swings-and-misses, keeping hitters off his fastball and slider.

Team Control. Detmers is signed at \$2.625M for 2026 (owed about \$825,000 post deadline) in his second arbitration year, with control through 2028 before free agency in 2029. At 26 he fits a multi-year window, not a two-month rental. The extra years of control will increase his acquisition cost, but it buys a pitcher who can provide serious stability for Atlanta in this playoff push and capitalize on their “win now” window the next two season.

Acquisition Economics

I valued Detmers' remaining control window in surplus value, defined as projected production in dollars minus projected arbitration salary, discounted to present value at 8%. I assumed the value of 1 WAR to equal \$10M.

Arbitration salaries are determined by traditional counting stats, like IP, Wins, ERA and Strikeouts, rather than underlying pitcher quality like Stuff+. Therefore, Detmers' 2026 salary is suppressed on two counts. His 2025 platform season came entirely out of the bullpen across 63.2 innings, contributing to his lower salary for the 2026 season. Since returning to the rotation in 2026 Detmers has shown above average stuff while pacing for a career high in innings, strikeouts and WAR setting him up for a sizeable raise entering his third arbitration. Detmers’ raise could be similar to that of Brady Singer in 2025, during his third time eligible jumping from \$4.85 to \$8.75. However, Singer started over \$2M ahead of Detmers so any projected gap in platform year WAR that Detmers has over Singer is not can’t justify a raise to overtake Singer. Other relevant comparable players in this section of the 3TAE market are Michael King and Trevor Rogers. Therefore, I project Detmers to receive a salary of \$7M in 2027 and \$11M in 2028

Year	Salary Projection
2026 (Arb 2)	\$2.625M
2027 (Arb 3)	\$7M
2028 (Arb 4)	\$11M

Year	WAR Projection ¹	Value (\$10M/WAR)	Projected Salary	Surplus Value	Present Value
2026	0.85	\$8.5M	\$0.8M	\$7.7M	\$7.7M
2027	1.9	\$19.0M	\$7.0M	\$12.0M	\$11.1M
2028	2.0	\$20.0M	\$11M	\$9M	\$7.72M
Total	4.75				\$26.52M

¹ WAR projections come from FanGraph’s public 3-year ZiPS Projections

Based on the table above, I've calculated Detmers' present-value surplus over his remaining 2.5 years of control to be \$26.52 million. Attaching a Qualifying Offer to Detmers following the 2028 season would likely net the Braves a Competitive Balance Round A pick (likely a 40 FV player), so I will add \$5M in value to bring Detmers' final surplus value to \$31.52M.

Below, I assigned each of the Braves' top prospects a Future Value grade, then applied FanGraphs' prospect valuation framework, scaling to \$10 million per WAR, to convert each FV to a surplus-value dollar figure.

Player	Position	Future Value	Surplus Value
Cam Caminiti	LHP	55	\$37.8M
JR Ritchie	RHP	55	\$37.8M
Eric Hartman	OF	55	\$51.1M
Tate Southisene	SS/2B	50	\$31.1M
Alex Lodise	SS	50	\$31.1M
Owen Murphy	RHP	50	\$23.3M
Briggs McKenzie	LHP	50	\$23.3M
Diego Tornos	OF	50	\$31.1M
John Gil	SS	45	\$8M
Garrett Baumann	RHP	45	\$6M

Caminiti, Ritchie and Hartman all exceed the surplus value of Detmers by themselves' and therefore should be considered "off the table" in this deal. Given their age and short samples in professional baseball, I would also not want to include Southisene, or Tornos in a deal at the moment. Additionally, the Braves just committed \$3M to Briggs McKenzie, well over his slot value in the fourth round of the 2025 MLB Draft, suggesting the organization's immense belief in his talent. This leaves Atlanta's strongest package including Owen Murphy and John Gil accumulating \$31.3M in surplus value. Murphy's proximity to the big leagues greatly reduces his risk while the Angels receive the upside in Gil who is just 20 years old. Due to scarcity at the deadline, the Braves would likely need to "overpay" for Detmers so if they are committed to making this acquisition, they could include another high floor/low ceiling prospect like Luis Guanipa (40 FV) to add roughly \$5M in surplus pushing Atlanta's package well over the threshold.

Conclusion

Reid Detmers is a valuable Starting Pitcher who the Atlanta Braves should acquire at the trade deadline because his peripheral statistics outperform his realized performance, he has stayed healthy thus far in 2026 and remains controllable through the 2028 season.

Owen Murphy and John Gil add up to \$31.3M against Detmers' \$31.52M of surplus. Atlanta keeps top prospects Cam Caminiti, Eric Hartman, and JR Ritchie. Murphy is already performing well in AAA which reduces his variance giving the Angels assurance he will be a viable major league pitcher. Gil is only 20 and gives the Angels long term upside.

Acquiring Detmers allows Atlanta to hands meaningful September and October innings to a proven commodity bound to improve rather than unproven depth.